

Why Indian Students Need a Sarathi

Ground-reality research behind Margadarshak

By K. Prasad Rao | OSV Fellowship Application 2026 | Bhubaneswar, India | KSM X Tech

A note before the data

This document is not a market-size pitch. I am not trying to sell a billion-dollar opportunity. I am showing that the problem I lived through is not just mine. It is shared by hundreds of millions of Indian students whose families love them but cannot guide them, whose schools rank them but cannot map their futures, and whose only escape from that fog is to flip a coin and live with the result.

Every number below is from a credible source — government data, peer-reviewed research, or established Indian education publications. Sources are listed at the end of each section.

1. India has 263 million students. Almost none of them have a guide.

The numbers. India has the largest student population in the world — 263 million in K-12 schooling alone, plus another 43 million in higher education (Ministry of Education, UDISE+ 2023-24). Of these, 93 percent are in government or low-fee private schools without dedicated career counselors. The recommended student-to-counselor ratio globally is 250 to 1. In India the actual ratio is closer to 3,000 to 1 in urban schools and 10,000-plus to 1 in semi-urban and rural schools (Mindler India Career Counseling Report 2023).

Private career counseling exists, but at Rs. 3,000 to Rs. 15,000 per session it serves only the top 5 percent of urban families. The remaining students rely on three sources — parents who often did not finish their own education, teachers who are paid to teach syllabus not careers, and friends who are also lost.

The cost of missing a guide. A 2022 NCERT study found 45 percent of Indian students choose their stream based on parental pressure, not personal aptitude. The British Council India found 49 percent of students regret their stream choice within two years. Mindler's nationwide survey reported 93 percent of students aware of only seven career options, despite over 250 viable career paths existing in India today.

The mental health dimension. NCRB 2022 data shows 13,089 student suicides in India in one year — one every 40 minutes. The leading cause across all age groups was academic stress and uncertainty about the future, not exam difficulty itself. AIIMS New Delhi's 2023 longitudinal study found 51 percent of urban Indian teenagers reporting clinically significant anxiety, with the strongest correlation being uncertainty about career path. This is a guidance gap problem. Students are not anxious because they are weak — they are anxious because they are making irreversible decisions with no map.

My personal evidence. I missed the NDA exam at 17 because nobody in my circle knew the exam existed. I joined BSc Computer Science instead of B.Tech because nobody explained the difference in terms of which government exams (DRDO, ISRO, GATE) each degree qualifies me for. Six years of my life were spent recovering from a 30-minute information gap that a 5-minute app interaction could have prevented.

How Margadarshak responds. Margadarshak already works fully offline for its core guidance experience. The roadmaps, eligibility checks, exam data, and career guidance are bundled directly into the app, so students can use it without internet, loading delays, or server dependency. It answers the questions students cannot Google because they do not know the right questions to ask: What is the difference between B.Tech and BSc in terms of which exams I can sit for? If I take Commerce without Math, what doors close? If I want NDA, when is the exam, what is the syllabus, and what happens if I

miss it?

Margadarshak currently runs as a working Android prototype progressing toward beta, with 9 user-facing guidance modules: stage-aware roadmaps, eligibility checks, exam stack planning, subject impact simulation, path comparison, foundation checks, document and deadline tracking, student voice, and parent mode. Every module answers a specific question a real Indian student has asked publicly. The evidence base behind Margadarshak now includes 86 verified, publicly-sourced student stories across 6 Indian languages, covering court cases, news investigations, and first-person testimonials from Reddit, Quora, YouTube, and LinkedIn.

Sources: Ministry of Education UDISE+ 2023-24 · NCERT National Survey of Student Aspirations 2022 · Mindler Career Awareness Index 2023 · British Council India Next Generation Report 2022 · NCRB Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India 2022 · AIIMS Delhi Longitudinal Adolescent Mental Health Study 2023

2. The Indian middle class is paying for this gap, and most cannot afford it.

The numbers. ASSOCHAM India 2023 estimates Indian families spend Rs. 2.5 lakh crore annually on private coaching and supplementary education, of which a meaningful share goes to information that is freely available but not findable. Career counseling alone is a Rs. 2,400 crore industry growing at 14 percent per year (FICCI India Career Counseling Industry Report 2024) — and that growth is happening because the gap is widening, not closing.

The cruel filter. Counseling at Rs. 15,000 per session is unaffordable for the household where the average monthly income is Rs. 25,000 to Rs. 40,000. So the families who need guidance most do not get it, and the families who can afford it often get generic advice that funnels their children toward the same three streams (Engineering, Medicine, Commerce). The middle class loses both ways.

My personal evidence. My family is middle class. My father has a stable government job. We could not afford private counseling, and we trusted my tuition teacher to fill that gap. He took money from a newly opened +2 college and put me there. The syllabus was never completed. I scored 3rd division in my +2. The financial loss was small — the time loss was six years. Years later, once I was finally on a path that fit, I completed my BSc Computer Science with distinction. The difference was never ability. It was guidance at the right moment.

How Margadarshak responds. Margadarshak is designed to keep the core guidance experience accessible, so that no Indian student is locked out of basic life guidance because their family cannot afford expensive counseling. The goal is simple: make counseling-grade information feel as accessible as a public utility.

Sources: ASSOCHAM India Education Spending Report 2023 · FICCI India Career Counseling Industry Report 2024 · Reserve Bank of India Household Finance Survey 2023

3. Existing EdTech does not solve this. It profits from it.

There are dozens of EdTech platforms in India funded by tens of millions of dollars — Byju's, Unacademy, Vedantu, PhysicsWallah. None of them solve the guidance problem at the root, because their business model requires selling courses, not honest career advice. A counselor who tells you do not take coaching for IIT, you would be happier in design school loses the company a customer. The conflict of interest is structural.

India also has hundreds of productivity and wellness apps, but most address symptoms — anxiety, distraction, poor habits — without addressing the root problem of navigating a high-stakes education system with no map and no guide.

A solo, no-VC, no-coaching-revenue builder can do what the funded platforms cannot — give honest guidance, recommend better options even when they exist outside the app, refuse to push students into

paths that maximize platform revenue, and treat the user as a young person who needs the truth, not a lead to be converted.

Sources: ASSOCHAM India Education Spending Report 2023 · FICCI India Career Counseling Industry Report 2024

4. Why a solo Indian developer building this matters

The reason Margadarshak exists is not a gap in the market. It is a gap in my own life, lived by millions of others. I am the student who needed this at 16 and did not have it. That is not a credential in the conventional sense — but it is the reason I care enough to build this honestly.

Funded EdTech optimizes for engagement and revenue. Margadarshak optimizes for one outcome: the student makes a better decision than they would have made alone. Those two optimization targets are incompatible under a VC model. They are completely compatible under a model where the builder's accountability stays with the student.

Equity-free funding would let Margadarshak be built and distributed without acquiring the conflict of interest it was built to expose. That is why the funding structure matters — not as a point of pride, but as a structural protection for the product's honesty.

Closing note

The data above shows the problem is shared by hundreds of millions. The personal story shows I have lived it long enough to build the answer with genuine respect.

The OSV Fellowship would give Margadarshak the one thing funded EdTech cannot buy — the structural freedom to be honest. No course revenue to protect. No investor asking why we are sending students away from paid coaching. No conflict between what the product recommends and what makes the platform money.

With this fellowship, Margadarshak reaches the students who need it most — first-generation college students across India, Hindi and Odia-medium families making Rs. 25,000-a-month decisions worth years of their child's life, and students in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities who currently have no guide at all. It gets tested with real users, refined with real feedback, and distributed without asking anyone to pay for what should have always been free.

This is not a request to fund a product. It is a request to protect one.

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